



and shared faith in Buddhism, unite the people living in these countries. Since Tibet's incorporation into the People's Republic of China many people have been influenced by modern

Chinese culture, however, most still practice Buddhism and retain many of their traditions. Ngari and U Tsang make up the Tibetan Autonomous Region where two-thirds of Tibetans live.

Tibetan Buddhism

By the eighth century Buddhism had already been introduced from India and it grew into a unique branch of the religion in Tibet over the following centuries. Tibetan monks have spiritual leaders called Lamas who belong to groups of monasteries.



PRAYER WHEELS

The practice of spinning prayer wheels and hanging prayer flags is common in Tibetan Buddhism. Prayer wheels are cylindrical wheels filled with rolls of paper that are printed with mantras (sacred texts) and prayers. Devotees spin the wheel clockwise while reciting the mantras and prayers.

DUNG-CHENS

Dung-chens are 10 ft- (3 m-) long horn trumpets used in Buddhist rituals. The bass tones are said to resemble the sound of elephants calling.



EDUCATION

A typical course of study in the Tibetan monastery lasts between 18 and 25 years and children begin as young as eight years old. During these years trainee monks study Buddhist philosophies as well as poetry, medicine, and art.

TIBETAN MONASTERIES

More than 6,000 monasteries were destroyed in the 1950s–1970s. Since then many have been reconstructed and other schools reestablished in Southern India. The monks here are debating—a popular part of their education.

